

EMBASSY OF ISRAEL IN AUSTRALIA NEWSLETTER

Welcome to the Embassy of Israel Newsletter: your window into the vibrant ties between Israel and Australia.

At a time of heightened regional complexity, we believe it is more important than ever to ensure access to accurate information and informed context on the issues shaping the current agenda.



This past week, the Embassy of Israel in Australia was confronted with false allegations of sexual assault made by participants in the Gaza flotilla. The claims appear to be part of a coordinated international smear campaign against Israel. The Embassy will continue to engage constructively with the Australian Government and relevant authorities on this matter.

Additionally, in this edition we will review the Memorandum of Understanding between the USA and Iran, to terminate the US-Iran confrontation pending the final outcome of the negotiations, as well as address the double standards against Israel for defending itself from terrorist entities. We also highlight local Israeli support for the aboriginal community, especially the project devised by the Nova Peris Foundation and Israeli NGO IsraAid, supported by the state of Israel, in the field of water security. To be noted, the special Victoria Parliament's Yom Ha'atzmaut event this week.

UPDATES ON THE US-IRAN MOU

A Memorandum of Understanding (MOU), to terminate the US-Iran military conflict, has been signed.

Over the next two months, the parties will conduct diplomatic negotiations aimed at reaching a comprehensive agreement, which is expected to include, among other things, a robust and definitive solution to existential threats posed by the nuclear program. Failure by the parties to reach a comprehensive agreement could put the military option back on the table. As President Trump stated in the G-7 press conference: "If you don't adhere to the agreement.. We are going to bomb the hell out of you".

Israel's position on the MOU is clear - With an agreement, without an agreement, Iran will not have nuclear weapons. Not today, and not tomorrow. Israel was always in favor of a diplomatic solution to the Iranian threats, and Israel expects that the comprehensive agreement will bring about a removal of the existential threats emanating from Iran for all times.

ACHIEVEMENTS OF THE MILITARY CAMPAIGN - IRAN

In the campaign against Iran, in historic cooperation with President Trump and the American military, Israel and the USA have prevented Iran from attaining an atomic weapon. Mass deaths have been prevented. Israel and the USA acted freely in the skies of Teheran, eliminating threats.

The State of Israel, in cooperation with the USA, successfully dealt a significant blow to two existential threats that existed prior to Operation "Rising Lion" (Am Kalavi)—the nuclear program and the ballistic missile program. Prior to the initial operation, Israel identified an attempt by Iran to make a significant leap forward in the development of these programs.

Iran has been significantly damaged militarily and economically by these two wars. A fear barrier has been crossed.

These threats, which pose a danger not only to Israel but to the entire international community, have been set back years.

Iran's oppressive arms like the IRGC and the Basij forces have been weakened dramatically. So also, the proxies have weakened significantly (Hamas, Hezbollah, and the Houthis), and Iran's ability to activate them against Israel and the west has been significantly reduced.

The struggle is not over and done, and Israel pledges that Iran will not have nuclear weapons.

With the removal of the fear barrier, opportunities open for new alliances in the region.

GAZA PR FLOTILLA

THE EMBASSY OF ISRAEL'S FORMAL STATEMENT IN REGARDS TO THE FLOTILLA MEMBERS

The Embassy of Israel in Australia notes recent reporting into allegations of sexual assault made by participants of the Gaza flotilla.

Currently, no credible evidence has been submitted to the Embassy to suggest that any flotilla participants were sexually assaulted. The claims appear to be part of a coordinated international smear campaign against Israel. As with any serious allegations, determination of guilt requires a full investigation and must be backed by credible evidence, not media interviews and hearsay. Until such a process has taken place, individuals are entitled to the presumption of innocence, as is standard in any democracy with a rule of law.

Until then, these allegations serve as nothing more than blood libels aimed at fuelling anti-Israel hatred and antisemitism worldwide.

It is important to note that the flotilla members are professional anti-Israel activists with a track record of fabricating stories. Some participants have been photographed posing as injured. They then reveal miraculous recovery, posing in subsequent photos looking very healthy. They claimed they were bringing aid to Gaza, but the flotilla carried no significant aid. They alleged that Israel was starving Gazans, but that has been disproven with facts and figures of humanitarian aid.

The Australian flotilla activists have provided inconsistent accounts and appear more interested in advocating for sanctions against Israel than advancing truth and human rights. The Australian activists also show no visible signs of injury, and the Department of Foreign Affairs and Trade indicated at Senate Estimates that no immediate medical treatment was required on arrival in Türkiye.

We also reiterate that some of the international flotilla members have documented links to organisations connected to Hamas and other terrorist groups, including IHH and the Popular Conference for Palestinians Abroad, which is an organisation designated by the United States. The United States has also imposed sanctions on activists associated with the flotilla. These links further expose the flotilla's true intentions.

It is outrageous and offensive that these futile allegations are continuing to receive such widespread attention and being accepted at face value by some activists and public commentators. This is disrespectful to genuine victims of sexual assault and rape.

It is also a moral outrage that some in the international community, including individuals who identify as feminists and women's rights advocates, have largely ignored or dismissed genuine, documented cases of sexual violence and rape by Hamas on October 7, 2023 while readily amplifying the flotilla allegations.

If only the victims of October 7 had received a comparable level of attention and support. Israel strongly and unequivocally condemns any acts of sexual violence, wherever they may occur.

Genuine footage of mistreatment has circulated online in relation to other countries, including Spain and Libya, yet these incidents have not provoked the same outcry. Once again, Israel is being subjected to double standards, showing this is more about political point scoring than genuine humanitarian concern.

Israel will continue to engage constructively with the Australian Government and authorities on this matter.

UPDATES ON ISRAEL-LEBANON

THE DOUBLE STANDARD AGAINST ISRAEL FOR DEFENDING ITSELF



*Photo credit: Michael Gottschalk/Photothek via Getty Images

Last week, Israel was the target of unprovoked attacks on multiple fronts by Iran and its terrorist proxies, including Hezbollah and the Houthis. Civilians in northern, central, and southern Israel ran for their lives throughout the weekend amid ballistic missile fire. In response, Israel carried out precise strikes in an act of self-defense, aimed at eliminating terrorist infrastructure. Ultimately, Israel faced backlash from multiple countries and leaders.

A notable example of the double standards was reflected in the post by UN Secretary-General António Guterres on June 14, in which he wrote: "I strongly condemn today's Israeli strikes on Beirut. The strikes took place despite the ceasefire and at a time when the US & Iran are expected to reach an agreement that will pave the way to a peaceful resolution of this conflict.."

Guterres failed to place blame on the true perpetrators, Hezbollah. Hezbollah is responsible for the suffering on both sides of the border, and, acting as a jihadi proxy for the Iranian regime, seeks to derail the direct peace negotiations between Lebanon and Israel.

Israel maintains that it remains committed to addressing threats through diplomatic efforts; however, if these attempts continue to fail, then Israel may have to renew its military effort.

HEZBOLLAH CEASEFIRE VIOLATIONS

SEVERAL SUSPICIOUS AERIAL TARGETS IDENTIFIED IN ISRAELI TERRITORY

Despite the ceasefire, Hezbollah has continued to launch missiles and drones from southern Lebanon toward Israel and its civilians. As of this week alone, Hezbollah has fired multiple projectiles at northern Israeli communities.

In response to these continued attacks, Prime Minister Netanyahu and Defense Minister Katz authorized an IDF surgical strike on a Hezbollah terrorist target in the Dahieh quarter of Beirut. Israel maintains that its operations are aimed at protecting its citizens from Hezbollah attacks and dismantling the terrorist infrastructure the group has built in the region.



Additionally, Israeli officials stated that Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu told U.S. President Donald Trump that Israel does not consider itself bound by the Lebanon clause in the emerging agreement with Iran, making clear that Jerusalem will not accept any arrangement that limits its freedom to act against Hezbollah.

LINKS BETWEEN HAMAS AND UNRWA

USAID REFERS FOR SUSPENSION/DEBARMENT 101 UNRWA STAFFERS DUE TO TERRORIST LINKS

Last week, the United States Agency for International Development's Office of Inspector General (USAID OIG) referred 101 current and former UNRWA employees for suspension or debarment consideration due to alleged involvement in the October 7 terrorist attacks and/or affiliation with Hamas's military wing, the al-Qassam Brigades.

According to the USAID OIG, those referred included school principals, teachers, security personnel, attendants, psychosocial counselors, and medical professionals. These findings raise serious concerns about the extent of Hamas infiltration within UNRWA and reinforce the need for greater accountability and oversight within international humanitarian organizations.

Following the report, UNRWA fired 70 employees in Gaza days later and released a statement that these measures would be effective immediately.



*Photo credit: Israel Defense Forces

However, the statement did not mention Hamas and stated that “the dismissal of the staff is not part of a disciplinary process and does not constitute in any way a validation of the claims made against them.”

Israel has repeatedly presented evidence that employees of the agency were actively involved in terror groups in the Gaza Strip, and that some participated in the October 7, 2023, Hamas-led invasion and slaughter. Organizations entrusted with supporting civilians must remain free from terrorist influence.

GLOBAL ANTI-SEMITISM

16TH EU-ISRAEL HIGH-LEVEL SEMINAR ON COMBATING ANTISEMITISM AND FOSTERING JEWISH LIFE

The State of Israel and the European Commission held yesterday in Brussels the 16th EU–Israel High–Level Seminar on Combating Antisemitism and Fostering Jewish Life. The seminar took place against the backdrop of a significant rise in anti-Semitic attacks across Europe and around the world following the heinous terrorist attacks perpetrated by Hamas against Israeli civilians on 7 October 2023.

Jewish communities continue to face anti-Semitic attacks in many European countries, including harassment, discrimination, hate speech, and physical violence, leading to an unprecedented level of anti-Semitic hatred since the Holocaust.

The Seminar serves as a unique platform for dialogue and the exchange of expertise and best practices between Israel and the European Union. It provides an important opportunity to reaffirm the shared commitment to strengthening cooperation in the fight against antisemitism and to ensuring an effective response to this growing challenge. Combating Holocaust distortion and denial, while preserving the memory of the Holocaust and ensuring that its lessons continue to educate and guide future generations, as an integral part of the fight against antisemitism, was also highlighted during the seminar.

Combating antisemitism requires not only responding to attacks after they occur, but also addressing its root causes through education in schools and academic institutions, particularly universities, which have increasingly become spaces where Jewish students face harassment, intimidation, and attacks. At the same time, greater efforts are needed to address antisemitism in the digital sphere, where hate speech, incitement, and harassment continue to spread.

The State of Israel remains deeply committed to the safety of every Jew around the world. At the same time, countries that are home to Jewish communities play a vital role in ensuring that all citizens can live safely, freely, and with equal rights. Combating antisemitism is not only about protecting Jewish communities; it is an essential part of strengthening inclusive, resilient, and democratic societies in order to foster a future based on security, freedom, mutual understanding, and respect for all.

UPDATES FROM ISRAEL

SOMALILAND OPENS EMBASSY IN ISRAEL'S CAPITOL JERUSALEM

Foreign Minister Gideon Sa'ar was honored to host President Abdirahman Mohamed Abdullahi at the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, during his historic State Visit to open Somaliland's embassy in Jerusalem. The Embassy of Somaliland is the eighth embassy open in Israel's eternal capital Jerusalem.

FM Sa'ar congratulated Somaliland on this bold and important step. Emphasizing that the friendship between Israel and Somaliland exists not only between the governments but also between the peoples. It is rooted in the hearts of the citizens of both countries.



LOCAL NEWS

AMBASSADOR MEETS WITH NOVA PERIS, ISRAAID CEO, AND LOCAL ISRAAID REPRESENTATIVES TO DISCUSS ONGOING PROJECTS



Ambassador Newman engaged with Olympian and First Nations activist Nova Peris, CEO of IsraAID Yotam Polizer, Managing Director of IsraAID Australia Yossi Eshed, and Bonface Kahi Mbege of IsraAID to discuss ongoing projects supporting Indigenous communities across Australia. The project discussed involved ensuring access to clean and safe drinking water in the Bokawa region.

He appreciated the opportunity to exchange ideas and looks forward to strengthening cooperation on future initiatives.

Further projects will be devised.

VICTORIA PARLIAMENT'S YOM HA'ATZMAUT RECEPTION

In a wonderful display of support of Israel, the Victoria Parliament's Yom Ha'atzmaut Reception took place this week, hosted by Zionism Victoria, the Zionist Federation of Australia, the JCCV, and ECAJ in honor of Israel's 78th Independence Day.

Joined by the Premier of Victoria, Hon. Jacinta Allan MP, the Leader of the Opposition, Jess Wilson MP, and fellow leaders and members of Melbourne's Israeli, Jewish, Christian, and other communities, it was a meaningful evening with an abundance of support for Israel.

In his remarks, Ambassador Newman spoke about the miracle of the survival and prospering of the State of Israel. He also referred to the shared values between Israel and Australia. He expressed deep appreciation to all those gathered. He related to the deep concern regarding the levels of hatred in Australia, against Jews and the State of Israel, noting that Anti-Zionism is just a cover for classic Anti-Semitism.

AUSTRALIA LOWERS OVERALL TRAVEL ADVICE FOR BAHRAIN, ISRAEL, KUWAIT, QATAR AND THE UAE

In a joint statement shared by Foreign Minister Senator Penny Wong and Assistant Minister for Foreign Affairs and Trade Matt Thistlethwaite MP, the following was stated:

The Australian Government has lowered travel advice for Bahrain, Israel, Kuwait, Qatar and the United Arab Emirates (UAE) from 'Do Not Travel' (Level 4) to 'Reconsider your need to travel' (Level 3). Some areas within Israel remain 'Do Not Travel'.

Level 3 remains a high threshold. We continue to urge Australians to postpone non-essential travel. 'Reconsider your need to travel' also means 'reconsider your need to transit'. If you need to transit these locations, stay as short a time as possible and eliminate unnecessary activities.

The Department and Foreign Affairs and Trade will continue to closely monitor the situation and keeps all Smartraveller travel advisories under review. Advice levels can go back up if conditions deteriorate. Australians should check [Smartraveller.gov.au](https://smartraveller.gov.au) for detailed, up-to-date advice before travelling and subscribe for updates.

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